▶ UTTAR PRADESH

MAYA JAAL

Parties in the I.N.D.I.A. bloc have long expected Bahujan Samaj Party (BSP) supremo Mayawati to field candidates who would cut the votes of their counterparts in the umbrella alliance. Congress and Samajwadi Party leaders have even called the BSP the 'B-team' of the ruling BJP. But when the BSP came out with its list of candidates, it proved to be a mixed bag. Sure, the party fielded seven Muslim candidates on minority-dominated seats in western UP, but on several important seats like Muzaffarnagar, Kairana, Mathura, Kanpur and Fatehpur Sikri, the BSP also gave tickets to forward caste and non-Yadav OBC candidates, something that could split the BJP votes as well. Polling in Muzaffarnagar and Kairana will be in the first phase. The BJP will find itself facing a united I.N.D.I.A. alliance on the one hand, and trying to build a strategy to stop the split in its forward-caste and OBC votes. The BSP has given a ticket to Dara Singh Prajapati, an OBC, from Muzaffarnagar and to Shripal Singh from Kairana seat. Those I.N.D.I.A. bloc candidates earlier accusing the BSP of helping the BJP are now thanking behenji off the record. The triangular contest, they hope, will help their cause. ■



Illustrations by **SIDDHANT JUMDE**



▶ MAHARASHTRA

AJIT VS THE PAWARS

Maharashtra deputy chief minister and Nationalist Congress Party (NCP) leader **Ajit Pawar** may be facing not just a political battle but a personal one too in family stronghold Baramati. Ajit, who is intent on fielding wife Sunetra against cousin and three-time Lok Sabha MP Supriya Sule, is finding himself increasingly isolated in the Pawar parivar. His younger brother, Shrinivas aka Bapu, has launched a scathing attack against him for deserting uncle Sharad Pawar. Addressing villagers in Baramati, Shrinivas said, "Some of my friends are saying the coming years will be of Dada (Ajit), not Saheb (Pawar). This thought caused me a lot of agony as we do not value an aged person because we want to take benefits from another person for the next 10 years. Those who think like this are very *nalayak* (useless)." He also spoke about how the senior Pawar had done so much for everyone. Though Shrinivas's son Yugendra said his father's words had been twisted and that, at the end of the day,